Strategic Legal Structuring and Capital Acquisition for Tech-Cultural Ventures under Status S and Swiss Social Assistance

1. The Legal Topography of Social Assistance and Innovation Funding in Canton Zurich

The intersection of Swiss social assistance (Sozialhilfe), refugee protection status (Status S), and institutional innovation funding presents a highly volatile regulatory topography. For a thirty-year-old individual holding Status S, residing in Canton Zurich, and currently sustained by social welfare, the acquisition of project capital for a tech-cultural venture—such as an interactive Visual Novel targeting mental health and burnout—requires meticulous, almost clinical legal structuring. The adjudicating committees of Swiss cultural foundations do not fund charity; they fund calculated risk with high cultural or technological returns on investment. Concurrently, the cantonal social authorities operate on a strict statutory mandate of asset liquidation and the minimization of state dependency.

The primary hazard in this ecosystem is the immediate suspension or aggressive reduction of vital social assistance due to the misclassification of project grants as personal income or liquid assets. The subsequent analysis provides an exhaustive framework for circumventing these statutory hazards through aggressive legal entity structuring, strategic narrative positioning, and hyper-targeted grant selection within the Swiss and European funding ecosystems. It outlines the precise mechanisms required to legally isolate project capital from personal welfare accounts, rebrand a multi-year employment gap as applied clinical and technological research, and secure specialized funding in a highly competitive environment.

1.1 The "Zuflusstheorie" and the Hazard of Direct Capital Inflow

Under the guidelines of the Swiss Conference for Social Assistance (SKOS), which are applied as binding legal and administrative benchmarks by the local social services (Sozialdienste) and social authorities (Sozialbehörden) in Canton Zurich, the personal finances of welfare recipients are subject to absolute monitoring.[1] The fundamental legal principle governing the calculation of social assistance eligibility is the "Zuflusstheorie" (Inflow Theory). According to SKOS guidelines implemented formally and aggressively since January 2021, any financial inflow to an individual prior to or during the period of state support is immediately classified as a liquid asset or disposable income.[2]

For a single person receiving social assistance in Canton Zurich, the absolute asset exemption

limit (Vermögensfreibetrag) is strictly capped at a mere CHF 4,000.[2] Consequently, if a cultural or technological grant—even a modest prototyping micro-grant of CHF 5,000 or a European solidarity grant of €7,000—is deposited directly into the personal bank account of a welfare recipient, it instantly breaches this statutory threshold. The local social service is legally obligated to classify this inflow as liquid assets available for the basic material needs of the individual (Grundbedarf für den Lebensunterhalt - GBL), leading to an immediate, proportional reduction or total cessation of welfare payments.[3]

Furthermore, social welfare recipients are subject to strict, legally binding obligations to mitigate their need for assistance, known as the "Pflicht zur Minderung der Bedürftigkeit," and must unconditionally declare all sources of income or capital inflow under the "Auskunfts- und Meldepflicht".[5] Attempting to receive project funding as a private individual while remaining on welfare is a strategic and financial failure. It results in the immediate cannibalization of the project's operational capital to pay for the founder's personal rent, basic food, and mandatory health insurance, effectively bankrupting the tech venture before development can commence.

1.2 The "Zweckgebundene Zuwendungen" (Earmarked Funds) Legal Exemption

To prevent the administrative confiscation of project capital, there is a narrow, highly specific legal exemption within the SKOS framework that must be aggressively utilized: the classification of funds as "zweckgebundene Zuwendungen Dritter" (earmarked third-party donations or grants).[3]

According to established SKOS administrative practice (Praxisbeispiele) and cantonal guidelines, earmarked financial performances or grants provided by independent third parties—such as philanthropic foundations, cantonal cultural funds, or European initiatives—are explicitly excluded from the welfare budget calculation, provided they fulfill stringent, verifiable criteria.[6] The critical legal requirement is that these funds must be strictly and contractually designated for a specific purpose that falls entirely outside the basic material needs covered by ordinary social assistance.[4] The funds cannot be fungible; they cannot be used to pay for the applicant's rent, basic groceries, or standard medical deductibles.

To operationalize this vital exemption, the grant application itself, and the subsequent legally binding contract with the funding body, must explicitly stipulate the targeted utilization of the capital. The documentation must prove that the funds are allocated exclusively for hard project costs—such as software licensing, server hosting, fees for external freelance artists, Unity or Unreal Engine asset purchases, or targeted marketing campaigns. The contract must explicitly state that the funds may not, under any circumstances, be diverted for the personal living expenses of the primary applicant. If the contractual architecture is structured correctly, the cantonal social welfare authority cannot legally offset these project funds against the applicant's monthly welfare payouts. However, executing this maneuver as a private individual remains administratively perilous, highly prone to misinterpretation by individual welfare caseworkers, and signals a lack of professional corporate structuring to the grant adjudicators.

2. Legal Entity Arbitrage: Establishing an Impenetrable Fiduciary Firewall

To eliminate the systemic risk of welfare suspension and to present a highly professional, de-risked profile to institutional grant adjudicators, the digital health and tech-cultural project must be entirely detached from the individual's personal legal and financial identity. The applicant must establish a separate legal entity.

For an individual currently sustained by social assistance, founding a standard commercial enterprise such as a Limited Liability Company (GmbH) or a Public Limited Company (AG) is legally and financially impossible. These corporate structures require verifiable, paid-in base capital of CHF 20,000 and CHF 100,000, respectively, which would immediately violate the SKOS asset limits if the individual possessed such funds. Therefore, the only viable, cost-effective, and legally robust vehicle available under Swiss law is the non-profit Swiss Association (Verein) governed by the Swiss Civil Code (ZGB).

2.1 The Swiss Verein (Art. 60 ZGB) as the Optimal Corporate Structure

The Swiss legal framework for associations, outlined in Article 60 and subsequent articles of the Swiss Civil Code (ZGB), is exceptionally liberal and provides immediate legal independence without the bureaucratic friction of mandatory commercial registration (Handelsregistereintrag) for non-commercial entities, nor does it require any minimum base capital.[8] By establishing a formally recognized Verein dedicated to a clearly defined non-profit purpose—such as "the promotion of mental health awareness, cultural integration, and psychological resilience through interactive digital media"—the applicant creates an impenetrable fiduciary firewall between the project's operational capital and the Zurich social welfare authority.

The establishment of a Verein requires only a founding meeting where written articles of association (Statuten) are formally adopted by a minimum of two founding members.[8] The applicant must recruit at least one trusted individual, ideally a Swiss citizen or permanent resident, to act as a co-founder and board member. Once the articles are adopted, the association instantly becomes a separate legal entity possessing corporate personhood.[8]

This separate legal personality is the crux of the strategy. The Verein can open its own corporate bank account. Grants, donations, and institutional funding awarded to the Verein legally belong to the Verein as an entity, not to its individual board members or founders.[8] Therefore, if the Verein successfully secures a CHF 50,000 production grant from Pro Helvetia or a CHF 30,000 Proof of Concept grant from the Future of Health initiative, the cantonal social welfare authority has absolutely no legal jurisdiction or claim over these funds. The capital is completely insulated from the applicant's personal CHF 4,000 asset limit.[2] Furthermore, highly lucrative foundations, such as the Ernst Göhner Stiftung or the Culture Helps Solidarity initiative, explicitly require applicants to be officially registered non-profit organizations or cultural entities rather than private individuals.[9] The Verein structure fulfills this strict baseline

eligibility criterion, transforming a vulnerable welfare recipient into a legitimate institutional applicant.

2.2 Board Compensation, Expense Reimbursement, and the Integrationszulage (IZU)

While the Verein isolates the project's capital and protects the welfare status, the applicant must legally justify their active, daily participation in the venture to the social authorities without triggering a reduction in their benefits. Under Swiss association law, board members of a non-profit Verein generally act on an honorary, unpaid basis, which aligns perfectly with the requirement to avoid generating personal taxable income that would reduce welfare payouts.[8] However, the applicant is dedicating substantial labor to coding, narrative design, and community management. The social services demand that recipients actively seek employment or engage in integration measures; thus, the time spent on the Visual Novel must be officially sanctioned.

The Canton Zurich social assistance framework includes a vital mechanism known as the "Integrationszulage für Nicht-Erwerbstätige" (IZU) – an integration allowance specifically designed for non-employed persons.[11] The IZU serves to financially recognize and incentivize individuals who participate in verifiable social, professional, or charitable integration programs.[11] The applicant's exhaustive work on the Visual Novel and their leadership role within the Verein must be officially declared to their social worker as a "Gemeinnützige Tätigkeit" (charitable activity) or a highly structured, self-directed professional qualification measure in the IT and digital arts sector.[11]

According to Canton Zurich's standardized IZU compensation scales, an adult engaging in 15 to 28 hours of such recognized integration work per week can legally receive an allowance of CHF 200 per month. If the effort is scaled to 29 to 42 hours per week (representing a 67% to 100% work pensum), the allowance increases to CHF 300 per month.[11] This allowance is added directly to the basic welfare payout and is legally exempt from being categorized as standard income that reduces the overall benefit.

Beyond the IZU, SKOS Chapter C.1.1 dictates that expenses incurred during voluntary or integration work—such as travel costs to tech networking events, specific material costs, or necessary communications infrastructure—can be formally covered by the social service or explicitly reimbursed by the Verein without being counted as deductible income, up to an imputed limit.[14] By formally registering the game development as a recognized integration activity, the applicant proactively legally justifies their time allocation, extracts a small but completely legal financial bonus from the cantonal welfare office, and simultaneously builds a verifiable track record of official local integration, which is highly advantageous for future residency permit upgrades.

2.3 Regulatory Compliance: Status S and the Amt für Wirtschaft und Arbeit (AWA)

A critical secondary legal vector that must be managed involves the applicant's specific residency classification. Status S (Schutzstatus S) grants temporary protection, allowing individuals to bypass the standard, protracted asylum procedure.[16] Crucially, unlike certain other temporary permits, Status S allows immediate access to the Swiss labor market, including the right to engage in self-employment.[17]

However, this right is not absolute and is heavily regulated. Any gainful employment, whether as a salaried employee or an independent contractor, must be formally authorized and monitored by the cantonal labor market authority, which in Canton Zurich is the Amt für Wirtschaft und Arbeit (AWA).[19] If the applicant decides to transition the Verein into a commercial venture in the future, or if they attempt to pay themselves a formal salary directly from the grant money secured by the Verein, they must notify the AWA prior to commencing.[21] The AWA reviews such requests to ensure absolute compliance with local wage standards and working conditions, preventing wage dumping.[20]

It is imperative to understand the legal friction between Status S labor rights and SKOS welfare constraints. While Status S permits self-employment, taking any salary from the Verein will immediately trigger the "Minderung der Bedürftigkeit" (reduction of need) clause enforced by the social services, leading to a franc-for-franc reduction in social welfare payments.[5] Therefore, during the critical pre-production and prototyping phases of the Visual Novel, the applicant must strictly maintain their legal status as an unpaid volunteer and honorary board member of the Verein. By exclusively utilizing the IZU allowance and expense reimbursement frameworks [11], the applicant ensures absolute compliance with both the AWA labor regulations and the SKOS welfare asset constraints, preserving their basic survival capital while building the tech venture.

3. Strategic Narrative Positioning: Rebranding the Employment Gap

To secure highly competitive Swiss innovation and cultural grants, the applicant's profile must be impeccable. Grant adjudicators at premier institutions like Pro Helvetia or the Migros Pioneer Fund are fundamentally risk-averse; they seek "Emerging Talents" with high trajectory potential, not liabilities.[23] A four-year gap in the applicant's curriculum vitae, characterized merely as "unemployment on social assistance," is a fatal signal of stagnation that will result in immediate administrative rejection. This chronological gap must be aggressively, legitimately, and creatively rebranded.

3.1 Reframing Unemployment as Independent Clinical Research and Tech Incubation

The narrative presented in the grant dossier's executive summary, CV, and project description must surgically frame the past four years not as a period of passive inactivity, but as a deliberate, self-directed period of applied clinical research, technological upskilling, and deep

community integration.

The applicant's active, documented involvement in local Swiss-Ukrainian volunteer groups, such as Herz2Herz, must be positioned as empirical sociological and psychological field research. The proposed Visual Novel explicitly addresses seasonal depression and burnout. The thousands of hours spent volunteering and interacting with displaced populations and traumatized individuals is the exact mechanism through which the applicant conducted comprehensive "target audience research" and "qualitative data gathering" regarding psychological strain, trauma, displacement, and the mechanics of resilience.[26] This transforms volunteer work into highly relevant subject-matter expertise.

Furthermore, the acquisition of AI certificates and the development of coding capabilities must be framed as the rigorous technical foundation phase of the project. The applicant has not been unemployed; they have spent the past years "bootstrapping advanced technological competencies" in AI and Web3/IT communities to ensure the cost-effective, highly innovative execution of the upcoming interactive media project.[27] This positions the applicant as a lean, capable technical founder who has utilized their time to eliminate the need for expensive external developers.

3.2 The Strategic Exploitation of the "Emerging Talent" Designation

This narrative reframing is not merely a semantic exercise; it is required to fulfill specific, rigid grant eligibility criteria. For example, Pro Helvetia explicitly targets and reserves funding for "Emerging Talents" in the Game Design sector.[24] The strict administrative definition of an emerging talent is a professional whose relevant training, education, or company foundation dates back less than seven years.[23]

By strategically framing the recent acquisition of AI and coding certifications as the formal "training period," the applicant perfectly aligns with this critical eligibility window. What the social services view as a four-year period of unemployment is legally transformed in the grant dossier into the applicant's formal technological incubation and training phase, effectively turning a perceived liability into the primary qualification for early-stage institutional funding.[23]

3.3 Dual-Axis Project Positioning: Cultural Artifact vs. Digital Public Health

The project itself—a Visual Novel exploring the mechanics of seasonal depression and featuring real, recognizable locations in Canton Zurich and Winterthur—must be positioned with extreme care to appeal to vastly different funding sectors.

For state and private cultural funds, the explicit use of real Winterthur and Zurich locations serves as a mechanism for "cultural promotion, regional identity representation, and spatial storytelling".[29] However, for health, innovation, and scientific funds, a Visual Novel is not merely an entertainment product; it must be classified as an "interactive digital health intervention," a "serious game for psychological resilience," or a "gamified prophylactic tool against burnout."

This dual-axis positioning allows the Verein to submit heavily modified applications to drastically different sectors simultaneously: applying as an arts project to a cantonal cultural office, and as a public health initiative to a medical foundation, thereby doubling the total addressable funding pool.

4. Hyper-Specific Grant Topography: Navigating the Swiss Funding Ecosystem

The funding landscape in Switzerland is highly decentralized, characterized by a complex web of cantonal, municipal, federal, and private philanthropic entities. Success depends entirely on precisely aligning the project's current development phase (ideation, pre-production, vertical slice, production) with the specific, often rigid mandates of targeted foundations.

4.1 The Premier Target for Narrative Interactive Media: Migros Kulturprozent Story Lab

The Migros Culture Percentage (Kulturprozent) operates a highly specialized initiative known as the "Story Lab," which acts as a dedicated test bed for audiovisual narrative formats, explicitly including games, interactive graphic novels, and virtual reality.[30] Given the narrative focus of a Visual Novel, this is arguably the most optimal, lowest-friction entry point for the applicant.

Strategic Alignment and Precedent: Unlike traditional film funding or conservative game funds that demand complete scripts or highly polished beta builds, the Story Lab focuses deliberately on the early developmental realization of an idea, supporting projects that are topical, socially relevant, and high-quality.[30] The focus on seasonal depression and burnout perfectly aligns with their mandate for social relevance. Furthermore, the Story Lab has established a direct precedent for funding this exact type of content, having previously funded "Cora," an interactive and science-based graphic novel specifically addressing the psychological impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic.[31]

Module Breakdown and Capital Extraction Strategy: The Story Lab operates through flexible, agile modules tailored to the specific needs of the project's current phase.[31] The applicant must target the Stufe I (Stage I) development modules initially:

- **Recherche (Research):** The applicant can request immediate funds for audience and topic research regarding the clinical definitions of burnout and seasonal depression. Crucially, this can cover the costs of consulting licensed psychological experts to ensure the game's narrative accuracy, elevating the project from an indie game to a science-backed tool.[31]
- **Gruppenarbeit (Exchange):** This module provides funding for interdisciplinary dialogue. If the applicant lacks native German or Swiss-German linguistic skills required for authentic localization of the script set in Zurich, this module can fund script consultations and translation fees with local Swiss writers.[31]
- **Sparring:** Vital for independent solo developers, this module provides paid access to an

international pool of mentors to consult on interactive dramaturgy, visual design, and transmedia format structures.[31]

The Story Lab's approach means the applicant does not need a finished product to secure initial capital, but rather a compelling narrative concept, proof of technical capability, and a clear social mandate.[31]

4.2 The High-Barrier Institutional Standard: Pro Helvetia Digital Culture

Pro Helvetia, the Swiss Arts Council, offers the most substantial and prestigious funding for digital games in the country, but its eligibility barriers are formidable and strictly enforced. It offers pre-production grants of up to CHF 20,000 and production "matching grants" of up to CHF 50,000.[28]

The Eligibility Crisis Regarding Status S: To establish the mandatory "Connection to Switzerland," Pro Helvetia's unyielding guidelines state that the project must be developed or implemented by practitioners who "verifiably hold Swiss citizenship or are permanent residents of Switzerland".[23] Status S is a temporary protection status, currently valid until March 2027, and is categorically *not* recognized as permanent residency (such as a C Permit).[17] If the applicant applies as a sole proprietor or independent individual, they face a 100% probability of administrative rejection before the project is even evaluated on its artistic merits.

The Strategic Bypass via Corporate Structuring: The applicant must utilize the aforementioned Verein structure to bypass this restriction. Pro Helvetia's specific rules for Game Design stipulate that "At least 50% of the participants are Swiss citizens or permanent residents whose place of work is in Switzerland".[28] By installing a Swiss citizen or permanent resident—perhaps sourced from the applicant's extensive Web3/IT communities or the Herz2Herz volunteer network—as a formal co-founder, board member, or recognized project partner within the Verein, the project immediately satisfies the geographic and citizenship requirements. This structural maneuver legally unlocks access to the CHF 20,000 pre-production grant.[28]

4.3 Navigating Cantonal and Municipal Geographic Funds

Because the Visual Novel features real, recognizable locations in Canton Zurich and the city of Winterthur, local geographic funds must be targeted to leverage regional identity.

Fachstelle Kultur Kanton Zürich: This cantonal office actively funds digital culture, explicitly encompassing interactive and transmedia storytelling, extended reality (XR), and digital art games.[34] The primary eligibility requirement is that the professional cultural practitioner has their verifiable residence and main work focus within Canton Zurich.[35] As the applicant has resided in Canton Zurich for 4 years, this geographic requirement is easily met, making the cantonal fund a highly viable target for project contributions.

Stadt Winterthur Kulturförderung (The Loophole Strategy): The city of Winterthur possesses a dedicated cultural budget of approximately CHF 600,000.[36] However, their project grants, which range from CHF 2,500 to CHF 10,000 for interdisciplinary projects, are explicitly targeted at "Winterthurer Kulturschaffenden" (cultural workers who have maintained their main residence or work focus in Winterthur for at least 3 years).[29] If the applicant resides in the city of Zurich or another municipality, they are strictly *ineligible* for Winterthur's primary cultural grants, regardless of how prominently Winterthur features in the game's narrative.[29] The strategic loophole lies in the exact phrasing of the requirement, which states the residency rule applies to "the central participants or several participants of the project".[29] To legally access Winterthur municipal funds, the applicant's Verein must officially contract or bring a Winterthur-based artist, sound designer, or scriptwriter onto the core project team, thereby anchoring the project geographically to the city's funding mandate.

4.4 Hyper-Targeted Integration, Refugee, and Mental Health Tech Funds

Beyond traditional game funding, the applicant's highly unique demographic profile (a Status S Ukrainian refugee) and the project's core theme (combating seasonal depression) unlock highly specialized, lower-barrier funding avenues that traditional Swiss game developers cannot access.

A. Culture Helps Solidarity (European Union / Creative Europe)

This is an optimal, high-probability target with immediate liquidity. The initiative, co-financed by Creative Europe, specifically offers grants designed to support Ukrainian arts and culture professionals, displaced persons, and refugees.[9]

- **Financial Scope:** The program provides grants of up to €7,000 for individuals, scaling massively to €20,000 or €30,000 for formalized partnerships between organizations.[9]
- **Strategic Relevance:** The project's mandate is the rebuilding of community connections, emotional healing, and resilience.[38] A Visual Novel exploring the psychological depths of burnout and depression perfectly aligns with their requirement for "participatory cultural formats" that create safe spaces for shared emotional experience.[38]
- **Execution Architecture:** Rather than applying for the €7,000 individual grant, the applicant's Swiss Verein should form a project partnership with a Ukrainian NGO, civic organization, or another EU-based entity to unlock the €30,000 maximum tier.[9] These funds can legally cover production costs, IT tools, software, marketing, and fees for external experts.[9] Crucially, this €30,000 can later serve as the "own funds" required to trigger the Pro Helvetia CHF 50,000 matching grant.[33]

B. The Future of Health Grant (CSS / EPFL Innovation Park)

If the Visual Novel is aggressively positioned as a digital therapeutic or a gamified preventative public health tool, the Future of Health Grant represents a highly lucrative, non-dilutive capital

source.

- **Grant Structure:** Supported by CSS insurance and the EPFL Innovation Park, they offer a tiered system starting with an "Ignition" grant of CHF 10,000 (Level 1) purely to kickstart venture ideas, progressing to a CHF 30,000 "POC" (Proof of Concept) grant (Level 2), and a CHF 50,000 "Validation" grant (Level 3).[39]
- **Strategic Advantage:** These grants are entirely equity-free and come with substantial operational support, including access to paid specialists and healthcare industry mentors.[39] Securing this grant effectively transforms the project from a localized "indie game" into a recognized, institutionally backed digital health startup, vastly increasing its valuation and prestige.

C. Beisheim Stiftung and Hasler Stiftung

The Beisheim Stiftung is a major philanthropic player in Switzerland focusing heavily on mental health, education, and social cohesion.[40] They specifically fund projects that aim to destigmatize psychological illnesses, strengthen mental resilience, and promote health literacy.[41] Applications are submitted online in a rigorous, multi-step process.[26] The applicant must emphasize the game's potential to reach a broad, vulnerable demographic (youth and young adults facing burnout) and its foundation in scientifically validated psychological concepts.[40]

Simultaneously, the Hasler Stiftung provides grants for Information and Communications Technology (ICT) projects for the benefit of Switzerland.[44] They offer a simplified application process for "Small Projects" requiring up to CHF 50,000.[27] Within their categories, "Research on ICT & Society" and "ICT Application Projects" fit perfectly.[27] By framing the Visual Novel as an innovative application of ICT methodologies to measure or mitigate societal psychological strain, the Verein can tap into funds designed for high-level academic and technological research.[27]

D. SINGA Switzerland and Startup Refugees Fund

While not a direct grant provider initially, SINGA Switzerland operates an incubator explicitly designed for entrepreneurs with refugee or migrant backgrounds.[46]

- **Strategic Advantage:** Participation in SINGA legitimizes the business model, provides a massive network, and grants access to a specialized microcredit program (CHF 5,000 to CHF 10,000) reserved exclusively for alumni.[46] Furthermore, nearly 50% of their participants hold refugee permits, meaning their mentors deeply understand the specific legal friction points involving the AWA labor regulations and SKOS welfare hurdles.[46]
- **Startup Refugees Fund:** Though based in Finland, this fund highlights a broader European trend of supporting newcomer entrepreneurs. The applicant should monitor similar pan-European funds that focus specifically on migrant tech founders, as they offer capital that bypasses traditional, conservative Swiss banking requirements.[47]

4.5 Comparative Matrix of Viable Capital Acquisition Targets

The following table synthesizes the optimal funding targets, illustrating the strategic alignment and the primary legal or operational hurdles for each.

Funding Body	Target Development Phase	Financial Scope	Primary Eligibility Hurdle	Strategic Alignment & Leverage
Culture Helps Solidarity	Ideation / Prototype	€7,000 - €30,000	Partnership with registered organizations required for higher tiers.	**Highest.** Directly targets Ukrainian refugees and mental health resilience. Provides rapid liquidity.
Migros Story Lab	Ideation / Narrative Dev	Modular (Variable, Phase-dependent)	Project must fit within their audiovisual narrative scope.	**Excellent.** Specialized in non-traditional narrative formats. Strong precedent with "Cora" graphic novel.
Future of Health Grant	Ignition / Proof of Concept	CHF 10,000 - 50,000	Must be positioned strictly as a digital health innovation, not mere entertainment.	**High.** Transforms the project into a recognized health-tech startup. Equity-free capital.
Hasler Stiftung	ICT Application / Prototype	Up to CHF 50,000	Must demonstrate ICT innovation	**High.** Validates the technological and societal

			serving public-interest goals in Switzerland.	impact of the applicant's AI/coding background.
Pro Helvetia (Pre-Prod)	Playable Prototype	Up to CHF 20,000	**Strictly requires 50% of the team to be Swiss citizens/permanent residents.**	**Medium.** Requires the applicant to install a Swiss co-founder to bypass Status S residency restrictions.
Fachstelle Kultur ZH	Project Production	Variable based on budget	Primary cultural worker must have main work focus in Canton Zurich.	**High.** Supports digital culture and interactive media natively without the severe residency limits of Pro Helvetia.
SINGA Microcredit	Post-Incubation / Launch	CHF 5,000 - 10,000	Must successfully complete the SINGA incubation program first.	**Medium.** Excellent for networking and mentorship, but represents a slower timeline to actual capital.

5. Execution and Deliverable Requirements: The Reality of Adjudication

Grant adjudicators in the Swiss tech, cultural, and medical sectors are ruthlessly pragmatic and highly critical. They are inundated with applications and do not fund abstract ideas, mere design documents, or well-intentioned charity cases. To access substantive capital—such as the Pro Helvetia CHF 20,000/50,000 tiers or the Future of Health CHF 30,000 tier—the

applicant must demonstrate extreme operational competence, technical mastery, and commercial viability through concrete, flawless deliverables.

5.1 The "Vertical Slice" and Playable Prototype Standard

In the Swiss game funding ecosystem, submitting a "Playable Prototype" or a "Vertical Slice" is absolutely non-negotiable.[24] A vertical slice is not a wireframe, a slideshow, or a rudimentary tech demo. It is a fully functional, highly polished, playable portion of the game that flawlessly showcases the final art style, the core interactive mechanical loops, the narrative tone, and the user interface.[24]

For a Visual Novel focusing on mental health, this means delivering a polished 10-to-15-minute sequence. This sequence must feature final (not placeholder) character sprites, actual, high-quality background art of the Zurich and Winterthur locations, fully implemented and bug-free dialogue branching logic, and integrated, atmospheric sound design. Most importantly, the prototype must demonstrate exactly how the game mechanizes the complex themes of burnout and depression interactively, rather than merely relying on static, passive text. If the applicant claims AI capabilities, the prototype must tangibly demonstrate how those AI elements enhance the narrative or streamline the production pipeline.

5.2 The Commercialization and Business Architecture

Adjudicators severely penalize projects that lack a rigorous route to market. Funding is viewed as a strategic investment in the Swiss creative and technological economy, not a sunk cost. The grant dossier must include an exhaustive commercialization plan comprising:

- **Target Group Analysis:** A deep, data-driven analysis of the demographics suffering from burnout and seasonal depression, cross-referenced with their digital consumption and gaming habits.
- **Market Positioning:** A ruthless competitor analysis. The applicant must compare their project to successful narrative games dealing with mental health, such as *Celeste* or *Night in the Woods*, or interactive graphic novels like *Cora*, explicitly detailing their unique selling proposition (USP).[31]
- **Distribution Strategy:** Clear, realistic pathways for release (e.g., Steam, itch.io, mobile app stores, or B2B distribution to health clinics) and defined pricing models.[33]
- **Financial Plan:** A highly detailed budget demonstrating where every single franc of the grant will be allocated (e.g., 30% for localizing text to German/French, 40% for freelance artists, 20% for marketing, 10% for software licenses).[28]

Crucially, this budget must reflect the absolute legal requirement that funds are strictly project-related (zweckgebunden). It must categorically exclude any allocation for the applicant's basic living expenses, thereby insulating the welfare status and proving to adjudicators that the funds are driving project value, not sustaining personal subsistence.[6]

6. Synthesized Strategic Roadmap

To successfully navigate the perilous transition from a welfare-dependent Status S refugee to a fully funded, legally compliant tech-cultural entrepreneur in Canton Zurich, the applicant must ruthlessly execute the following sequential roadmap:

1. **Establish the Fiduciary Firewall:** Immediately incorporate a non-profit Swiss Association (Verein) under ZGB Art. 60. Recruit at least one trusted Swiss resident as a co-board member and open a dedicated corporate bank account. This structure is the absolute prerequisite for protecting social welfare status from the Zuflusstheorie.[2]
2. **Optimize the Welfare Status:** Formally register the thousands of hours of work on the project with the local social worker as a recognized professional integration measure. Apply for the Integrationszulage (IZU) to legally extract up to CHF 300 per month [11], while utilizing SKOS C.1.1 to claim necessary project expenses.[14] Concurrently, aggressively reframe the past four years of unemployment as independent technological R&D and clinical field research.
3. **Structure the Corporate Team for Eligibility:** Bring a Swiss citizen or permanent resident onto the core project team to instantly satisfy Pro Helvetia's stringent 50% geographic requirements.[23] Contract a Winterthur resident to legally unlock localized municipal funds.[29]
4. **Execute Initial Capital Acquisition:** Apply immediately to the *Culture Helps Solidarity* initiative (€7,000 - €30,000) by partnering with an EU/Ukrainian NGO [9], and target the *Migros Story Lab* (Stufe I) for early research and narrative development funds.[31] Ensure all contracts explicitly mandate that the funds are "zweckgebunden" (earmarked exclusively for project costs).[6]
5. **Develop the Vertical Slice:** Utilize the initial capital injections and the applicant's established coding and AI skills to develop a flawless, highly polished Vertical Slice of the Visual Novel that mechanizes the experience of burnout.
6. **Scale Institutionally:** With a validated prototype, execute the dual-axis positioning strategy. Apply for the Pro Helvetia Pre-Production grant (CHF 20,000) treating the project as a cultural artifact [28], while simultaneously applying for the Future of Health "POC" grant (CHF 30,000) treating it as a rigorous digital health innovation.[39]

By strictly adhering to this legally insulated, strategically aggressive roadmap, the applicant can systematically neutralize the punitive mechanics of the Swiss welfare system, leverage their unique refugee status as a competitive advantage, and unlock top-tier innovation funding within the highly lucrative Swiss ecosystem.

Джерела

1. SKOS-Richtlinien - Schweizerische Konferenz für Sozialhilfe SKOS, доступ отримано квітня 14, 2026, https://skos.ch/skos-richtlinien/entstehung-und-bedeutung

2. Freiwillige Leistung Dritter - Sozialinfo, доступ отримано квітня 14, 2026, https://www.sozialinfo.ch/sozialrecht/rechtsberatung/freiwillige-leistung-dritter-VYqC3xAk/
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